

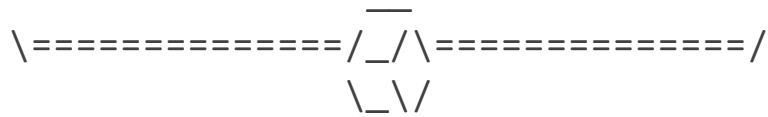
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The diagram consists of two main parts. The upper part is a hierarchical tree structure drawn with blue lines. It starts with a single root node at the top, which branches into two nodes. Each of these nodes further branches into two more nodes, creating a total of eight leaf nodes. The lower part of the diagram features a grid of vertical blue lines. There are four columns of these lines, each containing eight vertical segments. To the left of this grid, there are several orange lines and symbols, including parentheses and dots, which appear to be labels or annotations for the grid. A diagonal line of orange lines runs from the top left towards the center of the grid. The overall layout suggests a mapping or relationship between the hierarchical structure and the grid data.

v1.1

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Overview



ASCII Empires is a board game in which 1–7 players lead early Mediterranean civilizations through antiquity by advancing science and culture, constructing buildings and interacting through trade or conquest.

In this “roll-and-write” game, each civilization’s resources and progress in various fields are tracked on their Empire sheet. Each round begins with rolling of five dice. The players may negotiate to reroll some of them. Then, everyone uses the final results to mark their sheets. When any of several possible end game conditions is triggered, points are calculated. The player with the most points wins.

Components

Besides these rules, you will need:

- One Empire sheet per player (printable online)
- Pens or pencils
- 5 six-sided dice: 3 of one colour and 1 each of two different colours. The set referenced by the rulebook is 3 white, 1 green and 1 black dice, but any colours will do as long as the players can tell them apart.

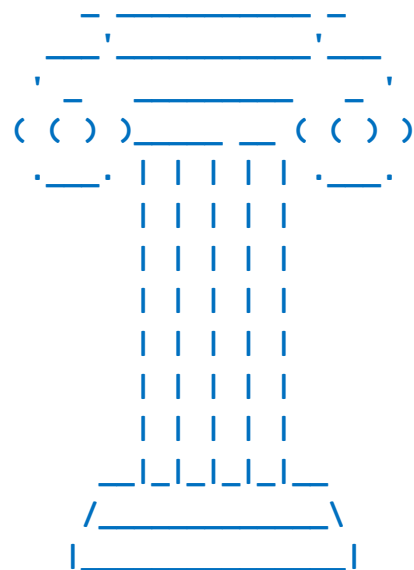
You may name your Empire and give it an Emblem (e.g. your initials or a small picture). The Emblems are used for flavour but also to distinguish different players’ Colonies from one another (p. 8).

You are then ready to start playing!

Setup

Print an **Empire sheet** for each player. A4 size is recommended; if you plan to play several games, printing on both sides of the paper helps conserve trees.

Players should sit around a table facing each other. The tablespace in the middle is **the Mediterranean**. (The fact that the top side of each Empire’s map borders on water serves as a reminder.) This seating order informs which Empires are connected at the start of the game (see *Reach*, p. 7).



The Empire Sheet

The **Population track** shows Workers (/) which can be trained as Soldiers or Specialists.

Gold can be spent for various useful actions.

The **Military track** shows Armies which can be Deployed to attack other players or to defend from attacks.

Each **round** consists of five phases.

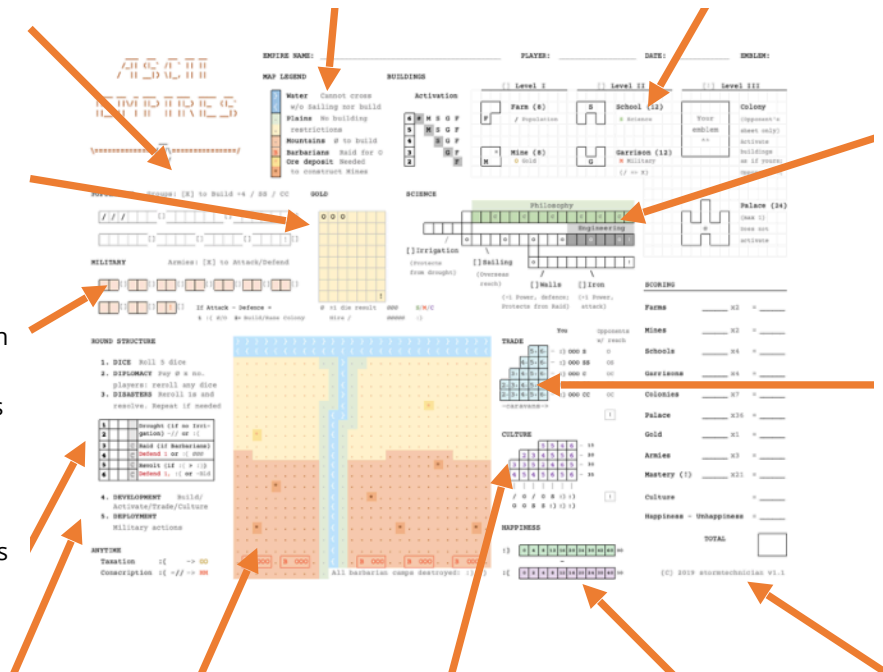
Disasters are negative events that may occur as 1s are rolled and the rows of the Disaster grid become filled. Some of them can be avoided with the right preparation.

The **legend** on the top explains map features, available Building types and the dice needed to activate each type.

Buildings, once constructed, can be activated to produce resources or to advance the various tracks of your Empire.

The **Science track** unlocks additional dice, increasing your Empire's power as the game proceeds. Its branches also provide new powers and other benefits.

Completing **Caravans** increases your Empire's Happiness and provides other benefits to you *and* to other players.

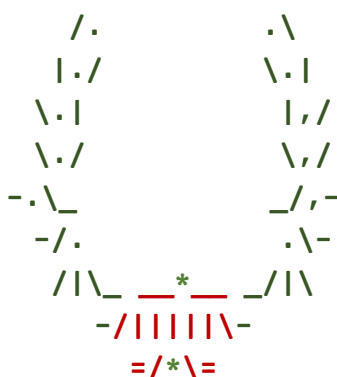


Buildings are constructed on the **Map** by connecting the dots of the grid. Colours and "*" symbols reflect terrain features which have some gameplay significance (summarised on the Legend)

Filling the boxes of the **Culture grid** represents advances in arts and provides points and various useful bonuses.

Some game effects add **Happiness** or **Unhappiness** which may influence your score considerably. Unchecked Unhappiness also may trigger the "Revolt" disaster.

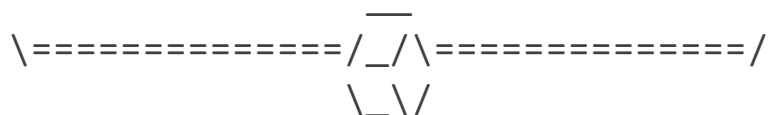
The end game **scoring** reflects your Empire's progress in various fields.



ASCII Empires was inspired by Sid Meier's *Civilization* series, Wolfgang Warsch's excellent *Ganz Schön Clever* and the 1967 ASCII character encoding standard. The game uses the fonts *Courier Prime* (by Alan Dague-Greene) and *Open Sans* (by Steve Matteson), both licensed under the Open Font License.

In addition to them, the author would like to thank the wonderful playtesters of *ASCII Empires* and everyone else who offered comments along the way.

Playing the Game



Round Structure

ASCII Empires is played in rounds. With the exception of the solo mode (see p. 12), the number of rounds is not set beforehand. Instead, the game continues until one of several end game conditions (p. 11) is met.

Each round consists of five phases:

1. **Dice:** The five dice are rolled. (Any player may do this as the results will be shared between all players.)
2. **Diplomacy:** Players discuss the results and may collectively spend Gold to reroll some of the dice (p. 10).
3. **Disasters:** All dice still showing the value 1 are rerolled, which may result in Disasters being triggered (p. 10).
4. **Development:** Players use the die results available to them to take various actions. (All players can perform this phase simultaneously.)
5. **Deployment:** Players may Deploy Armies to perform one or more military actions (p. 8).

The players then begin another round if no end game condition has been met. Otherwise, the scores are calculated and the player with the most points wins.

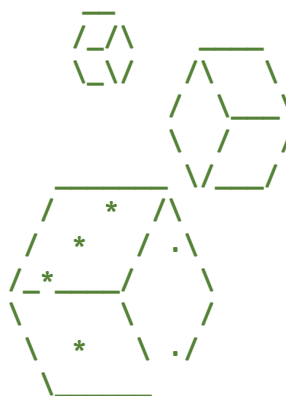
Development

In the Development phase, players use the dice to improve their Empires. Each die can be assigned to one of the following actions:

- Constructing buildings (p. 5)
- Activating a building type (p. 5)
- Trade (p. 9)
- Culture (p. 9)

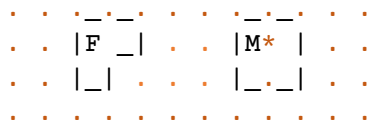
The following rules always apply:

- Actions may be taken in any order.
- Each action may be taken several times.
- Each individual die may only be used once per player per round.
- The players' decisions are independent of one another. (Players need not use a given die in the same way.)
- You may only use dice that are available to you based on your progress on the Science track (p. 7). At the beginning of the game, only white dice are available. (The green and black dice are still rolled for the purpose of checking for Disasters.)



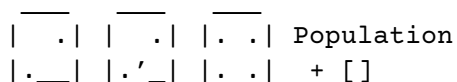
Buildings

Construction is one of the main ways for the Empire to expand. **Buildings** are constructed by connecting dots on the map with lines. (A connection between two adjacent dots counts as one line.)



The (F)arm and the (M)ine take 8 lines each to complete. Note that the Mine has to be built around an Ore deposit ().*

The number of lines you may draw on a round is equal to the combined value of dice used for construction. You may use one or more Great Person bonuses from the Population track (p. 6) to increase this by 4.



Example: Three dice display the values 2, 3 and 4 and you have 1 Great Person (p. 6). If you use all three dice for construction, the total number of possible lines is $2+3+4 = 9$, enough to construct a Farm or a Mine. The remaining 1 would be lost since no buildings can be constructed with a single line. Alternatively, you could use only the "4" result and the Great Person bonus of +4, sparing the "2" and "3" results for activating buildings, Trade or Culture.

There are **six different building types** (Table, p. 6) divided into three **Levels**. To build a Level II building, you need at least one staffed building of each Level I type. Level II buildings are similarly a prerequisite for Level III buildings.

Constructing both Level III buildings triggers the end of the game and provides a "Mastery" scoring bonus.

Some rules always apply to constructing:

- Any number of buildings can be constructed on a round.
- A building has to be completed (its outline fully drawn) on a single round. (You may not start constructing a building and finish it on a later round.)
- Buildings may not touch or overlap, even at corners (including with buildings previously destroyed by game effects).
- Buildings must be constructed in the orientation shown on the Empire sheet. (You cannot rotate them.)
- If any part of a building's outline would intersect Mountainous terrain, you must spend 1 Gold. (If you have no Gold, you may not build there.)
- The Mine building type must be constructed around an Ore deposit ("*"). These are mostly, but not exclusively, located in the Mountains.

A building may be **staffed** (with a letter inside) or empty. The Palace needs no staff.

- To staff a building, cross over one of your available workers ("I" becoming "X") and mark the letter (e.g. "F" for Farmer) inside the building. The Worker is now a Specialist working in that building.
- You must staff buildings on the round they were constructed on, if able. (You cannot carry both empty buildings and idle workers from one round to the next).

Staffed buildings can be **activated** using a die. When activated, each building produces a distinct advantage (Table, p. 6).

- You may use a single die to activate all of your buildings of the same type.
- A single die may only activate one type of building.
- A building may be activated any number of times each round.
- A building may be activated on the same round it was built on, provided it is staffed and a suitable die is still available.

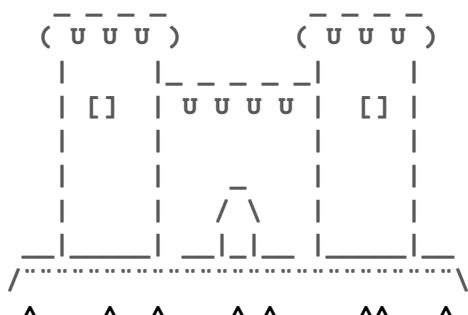
Level	Name	Lines to complete	When activated
I	(F)arm	8	Add a new Worker ("/") to the population track
	(M)ine	8	Add 1 Gold ("O") to the Gold track
II	(S)chool	12	Mark the leftmost box of the Science track (or any one of its two branches)
	(G)arrison	12	Cross off a Worker to make a Soldier (mark the leftmost box of the Military track)
III	(#) Colony	None	You may activate any one building type as if affected opponents' buildings also belonged to you. The opponents gain 1 Unhappiness.
	Palace	24	N/A (The palace is never activated, nor does it need a Specialist: it is where <i>you</i> live. You may only build one.)

To activate a building, the die must have a high enough value. Farms can be activated with a die equal to or greater than 2, while Mines can only be activated with a 5 or 6. The requirements are shown in the table.

6	#	M	S	G	F
5		M	S	G	F
4			S	G	F
3				G	F
2					F

A "6" may activate a Colony or any other building type. A "3" can activate Garrisons or Farms, while a "2" may only activate Farms.

Example: You have two Schools and a Farm and access to dice showing the results 2, 4 and 5. You could, for instance, use both 4 and 5 to activate the two Schools twice (for a total output of 4 Science) and the 2 to activate the Farm (to produce one Worker).



Population

To grow, your Empire needs citizens. **Workers** are produced by Farms and recorded on a player's **Population track** with slashes ("/"). You start with three (preprinted on the sheet). Workers can:

- Become Specialists who staff buildings and enable them to be activated (p. 5).
- Be trained as Soldiers when activating Garrisons (p. 8).

Whenever a group of boxes of the Population track is completely filled in (with Workers or Specialists), a **Great Person** appears. You may then at any time check the smaller box next to the group to choose one of the following:

- Draw 4 lines to the map for the purpose of building.
- Mark 2 boxes on the Science track.
- Mark any 2 boxes on the Culture grid.

Filling the entire Population track triggers the end of the game and provides a "Mastery" scoring bonus.



Gold

Gold is produced by Mines but can also be gained by advancing Trade, Science and Culture. Available Gold is recorded on the **Gold track** by drawing coins ("O") inside the squares. When spent, the coins are crossed off ("Ø").

There are many uses for Gold:

- 1 Gold lets you modify a die value by 1 in either direction for the purpose of construction, building activation, Trade or Culture in the Development phase. The same die can be modified several times by spending more Gold. Do not turn the die (it retains its original value for the other players). A modified die value may exceed 6 (it does not flip over to 1) but cannot go lower than 2.
- 1 Gold lets you hire a new Worker. (Add "/" to Population track.)
- 3 Gold lets you mark one box of a Science, Culture or Military track (reflecting patronage of professionals or hiring of mercenaries).
- 5 Gold lets you increase Happiness (p. 10) by one (representing bread and circuses to the people).
- Gold can also be spent for rerolls in the Diplomacy phase (p. 10).

Filling the entire Gold track triggers the end of the game and provides a "Mastery" scoring bonus.

Science

Scientific progress gives your Empire access to extra dice and other bonuses, increasing your options and allowing more powerful rounds. Science is produced by **Schools**. Each time one of your Schools is activated, you may mark the leftmost box of your Science track. The track branches at certain points: once past these, you may mark boxes in any branch you have

unlocked. The upper branch of the Science track represents humanities; the middle and lower branches represent natural sciences.

Various points on the track provide one-time or lasting benefits upon researching them (when the indicated box is marked).

- *Irrigation* makes you immune to the Drought disaster.
- *Philosophy* (the first box of the upper shaded area) gives you access to the Green die for the rest of the game.
- *Engineering* gives you access to the Black die for the rest of the game.
- *Sailing* gives you Reach (see next section) to all other players for the purposes of military actions or trade.
- *Walls* makes your Armies (p. 8) more powerful for the purposes of defence and make you immune to the Raid disaster.
- *Iron* makes your Armies (p. 8) more powerful for the purposes of attacking.
- Whenever you mark a box with a "C" symbol, you may mark any one box on the Culture grid.
- Whenever you mark a box with a "O" symbol, you may gain one Gold.

Finishing any branch of the Science track triggers the end of the game and provides a "Mastery" scoring bonus.

Reach

In multiplayer games, it is relevant to know which players have **Reach** to one another for the purposes of military actions or trade. This is determined by two things:

- Seating order: players sitting next to one another always have Reach to each other (exception: 2-player games, p. 12).
- Progress on the Science track: once a player has researched *Sailing*, their Reach will expand.

Reach is best visualised as the ability to cross the “water” that separates the players and board areas. At the beginning of the game, your Caravans and Armies cannot cross water. They can move into the Empire on your immediate right or left; however, they cannot cross the river that divides those boards, nor can they cross the Mediterranean to reach the players on the opposite side of the table. Thus, at the beginning of the game, you have Reach to the right side of your left-hand neighbour’s board and to the left side of your right-hand neighbour’s board. Once you have researched *Sailing* (p. 7), you have Reach to all areas of all players’ boards.

Military

The art of war is of vital importance to the Empire. Mustering and deploying armies allows you to attack opponents or establish a Colony in their territory. There are also the Barbarians, a non-player enemy faction which you can wage war against.

Military units are produced by **Garrisons**. Each time one of your Garrisons is activated, you may cross off a Worker from your Population track (“/” becoming “X”) and mark the leftmost box of your **Military track**. The Military track is arranged in cohorts of 2 boxes. A fully filled cohort becomes an **Army**. Marking the final box triggers the end of the game and provides a “Mastery” scoring bonus.

You can **Deploy** Armies in the Deployment phase. To deploy an Army, check the smaller box next to it (to show it has been used) and gain 1 point of **Power** (2 points instead if you have researched *Walls* or *Iron* and are the defending or attacking player, respectively). You may deploy several Armies at once. As an attack is being resolved, players may deploy additional Armies. Only after no one wishes to deploy

any more Armies are the effects resolved. Deployed Power must be used instantly for military actions: it does not carry over to the next round.

You may use points of Power to attack:

- 1 pt: *Destroy a Barbarian camp*, provided there are unraided Barbarian camps on a sheet you have Reach to (p. 7). This yields you three Gold (OOO). When all camps on your sheet are destroyed (regardless of who destroyed them), you also immediately gain 2 Happiness.
- 1 pt: *Attack another player’s Empire* to whom you have Reach. They gain 1 Unhappiness and lose 1 Gold (if able). If they lost Gold, you gain 1 Gold.
- 2 pts: *Establish a Colony* on another player’s territory where you have Reach to. This counts as an attack.
- 2 pts: *Raze an opponent’s Colony* on your territory. The Colony is crossed over and cannot be activated.

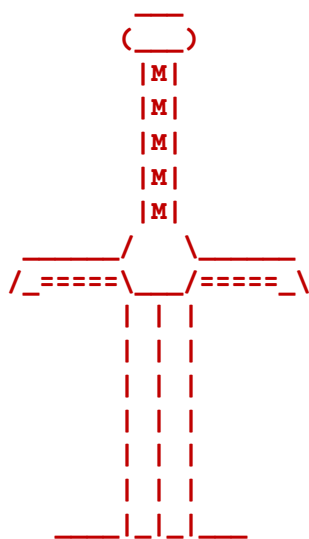
You may use points of Power to defend against attacks:

- 1 pt: *Cancel a Barbarian raid* on your Empire (see Disasters, p. 10).
- 1 pt: *Reduce the Power* of an opponent’s attack on you by 1.
- 1 pt: *Reduce the Power* of an opponent’s attack on another player by 1, provided you have Reach to the defender.
- 1 pt: *Prevent the destruction* of your Colony by the Revolt disaster (p. 10).

Colonies are permanent settlements on other players’ territory. A Colony can only be established by a successful attack with Power 2 or more. To establish a Colony, draw a 5x5 area on any free area on the opponent’s map you have Reach to. Mark it with your Emblem. The Colony may not touch or overlap other buildings. If its outline intersects Mountainous terrain, pay 1 Gold. The opponent may not build in the area of another player’s Colony.

Example: Carthage has three Armies and Rome has one. The Carthaginian player deploys two Armies (for 2 Power) to establish a Colony in Rome. The Roman player deploys his only Army, reducing Carthage's Power to 1. The Carthaginian player now has a choice: she may use the single point for a regular attack or establish the Colony by deploying her remaining Army for a total of 2 unopposed Power.

During the Development phase, Colonies can be activated with a "6" die result. Colonies need to be staffed in order to be activated. When activating a Colony, you can activate any one building type, counting both your own buildings and the colonized players' buildings (as if they belonged to you). Those players then gain one Unhappiness.



Trade & Caravans

Trade can make several Empires better off. Acquiring exotic goods makes citizens happier but also lets other players earn Gold. Unlike Population, Gold, Military and Science, Trade is not produced by a building. Instead, die results may be allocated directly into one of the five Caravans of varying length.

Caravans are completed as follows:

- To mark a box, you have to use a die with the specified value or higher.
- The boxes of a Caravan have to be marked in order from left to right.
- Rows can be completed in any order.
- You may have several unfinished Caravans travelling at once.
- There is no limit to how many Caravan boxes you can mark per round if suitable dice are available.

When the last box of a row is marked, the Caravan has reached its destination. You must announce this to the other players. You will then receive the reward indicated to its right: Happiness, Gold, and Science or Culture. Also, each other player with Reach (p. 7) to your Empire earns the reward listed on the sheet.

Marking every box of the Trade area triggers the end of the game and provides a "Mastery" scoring bonus.

Culture

Patronage of the arts adds to the prestige of your civilization. Cultural progress allows you to gain Gold, Population, Science or Happiness as creative people from all around the known world flock to your Empire.

You can mark boxes of the **Culture grid** by using a die with the indicated result. As a row or column of the grid is completed, you gain the associated reward. Rows provide points for end game scoring; columns provide one-time rewards. The boxes may be marked in any order.

Marking every box of the Culture grid triggers the end of the game and provides a "Mastery" scoring bonus.

Diplomacy

The Diplomacy phase comes directly after the dice are first rolled at the beginning of a round. The players have a chance to reroll any or all dice; for example, those with a value of 1 (and thus, about to trigger Disasters in the following phase).

A reroll can only be made if the players, collectively, spend Gold equal to the number of players in the game (e.g. 0000 in a 4-player game). The cost is paid only once per reroll, no matter the number of dice rerolled. Any number of dice can be rerolled any number of times.

The Gold requirement can be met by each player paying one Gold, but this need not be the case. One player alone may choose to pay the full cost, or players may agree to split the cost in another way. If there are several different proposals for rerolls, follow the Order of Play rules to determine who goes first (p. 12).

Disasters

The Empire is under constant threat from natural calamities and Barbarian raids. Each round, **Disasters** are checked for after the Diplomacy phase, following this procedure:

1. If any dice at this stage show the value "1", they are separated from the rest and rerolled. If any 1s result from the reroll, repeat the process until no 1s remain.
2. Each player looks at the results and checks the leftmost matching empty box on the Disaster grid.
3. The dice are then placed with the rest and may be used normally during the ensuing Development phase.

Whenever the third (shaded) box of any Disaster grid row is marked, that Disaster hits. One row may only trigger once; if

those numbers are later rolled again, nothing happens. Some Disasters only trigger under certain conditions.

- *Drought* only affects players who have not yet researched Irrigation (p. 7). The affected player must cross off two Workers or gain one Unhappiness.
- *Barbarian raid* only happens if there are still undestroyed Barbarian camps on your player sheet and you have not researched Walls. It can be prevented by Deploying 1 Army. If you cannot or choose not to do so, lose three Gold (if able) and gain one Unhappiness.
- A *Revolt* only affects players whose Unhappiness (in terms of boxes marked) is larger than their Happiness. It can be prevented by Deploying 1 Army and gaining 1 Unhappiness. Otherwise, a building of your choice is destroyed and cannot be used for the rest of the game. No new buildings may be built in the same space. You may choose an opponent's Colony as the target, but they may prevent its destruction by deploying 1 Army. In this case, you must choose another building.

Hardship breeds creativity: the triggering of some Disasters (indicated with a "C") allows you to mark any one box from the Culture grid, regardless of if you actually suffered negative consequences from the disaster.

Happiness

A good ruler cares about the Happiness of their subjects. A happy population provides points at the end of the game, but creeping Unhappiness may counter some of the gains and provoke Revolts (see above).

Happiness is gained through Trade (p. 9), Culture (p. 9) and military victory over Barbarians (p. 8). Unhappiness results from Disasters, opponents' attacks and Colonization of your Empire (p. 8), and

Conscription and Taxation (see below). Whenever you gain Happiness or Unhappiness, mark the leftmost empty box of the corresponding track. The box just right of it shows your current score. Neither Happiness nor Unhappiness may exceed the track. Unhappiness is deducted from Happiness in the end game scoring. This may result in a negative score.

Conscription and Taxation

If you find your coffers empty or enemy forces at your gate, you may gain one Unhappiness to immediately gain two Gold (Taxation) or to convert up to two Workers to Soldiers (Conscription). No Mines or Barracks are required for these actions. Taxation and Conscription can be performed anytime (including as reaction to an unfortunate dice roll or another player declaring an attack against you) and can be repeated as many times as needed.

End of the Game

The end of the game is triggered as soon as any player has completely filled any of their tracks (Population, Gold, any branch of the Science track, Military, Trade, Culture) or constructed each Level III building type – that is, whenever a “!” symbol is marked. A player about to take a game-ending action must announce it at the beginning of that Development phase. Otherwise, such action may not be taken. An exception is when you trigger the end of the game by influencing an opponent’s sheet (e.g. by completing a Caravan that causes the final

box in their Culture grid to be marked). After the final Development phase and the ensuing Deployment phase, the points are calculated and the player with the most points wins. If several players are tied for most points, follow the tiebreakers (p. 12).

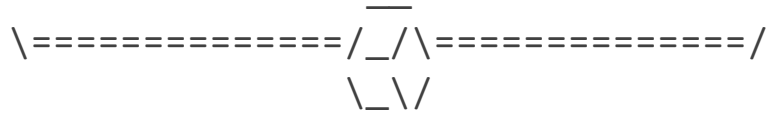
The scoresheet is part of the Empire sheet. The following items are scored:

- Buildings: the indicated number of points for each of building of that type. Destroyed buildings do not count.
- Gold: two points for each unspent Gold
- Armies: three points for each Army (deployed or undeployed)
- Mastery: 21 points for each “!” symbol marked (it is possible to reach several during the final round)
- Culture: total points from all completed rows of the Culture grid
- Happiness minus Unhappiness: leftmost unmarked number on “:;)” track minus leftmost unmarked number on “:/(” track.

Symbols

O	Gain 1 Gold
∅	Spend 1 Gold
/	Gain 1 Worker
–/	Cross off 1 Worker
:)	Gain 1 Happiness
: (	Gain 1 Unhappiness
S	Mark a box on Science track
M	Mark a box on Military track
C	Mark a box on Culture grid
!	End game trigger / Mastery bonus

Fine Points & Variants



Learning game

For the first few rounds in a game with new players, it is recommended that the players take their Development steps sequentially in clockwise order so that everybody can see how the dice are used. (Everyone still uses the same set of dice.)

1 or 2 Players

Any number of players can join a game of ASCII Empires. For practical purposes, 1–7 is recommended. For 1–2 player games, make the following adjustments.

In a **solo game**,

- You can still use Caravans and interact with Barbarians.
- Once all Barbarian camps are destroyed, you may build exactly one Colony to the Barbarian's land following the normal rules (it does not take space on your map; just mark it next to it). When using it, you may activate any building type as if you had 2 more of those buildings.
- The game ends after 20 rounds. Other triggers do not cause the game to end (but you still get any Mastery bonuses you meet). Try to beat your high score!

In a **two-player game**,

- The players do not have Reach to one another at the beginning of the game (they are located on opposite sides of the Mediterranean). They may only gain Reach through researching *Sailing*.

Open Information

Players may inspect each other's sheets at any time. Though the Development phases are played simultaneously, there are two instances in which a player has to announce to others what they are doing:

- Whenever they complete a Caravan (as this may provide benefits to others)
- Whenever they plan to trigger the end of the game.

Order of Play & Tiebreakers

The order in which players execute their actions mostly does not matter. Whenever it could (mostly in the Diplomacy or Deployment phases, though players may invoke this rule at any time), actions are declared in the order of:

1. the most undeployed Armies, or if tied,
2. the most unspent Gold, followed by
3. the most advanced single Science track, followed by
4. the highest population.

Follow the same logic for tiebreakers in end game scoring.